BISC & Workbench Strategy Research: Multi-State Ballot Initiative Research Findings February 2026

Key Findings

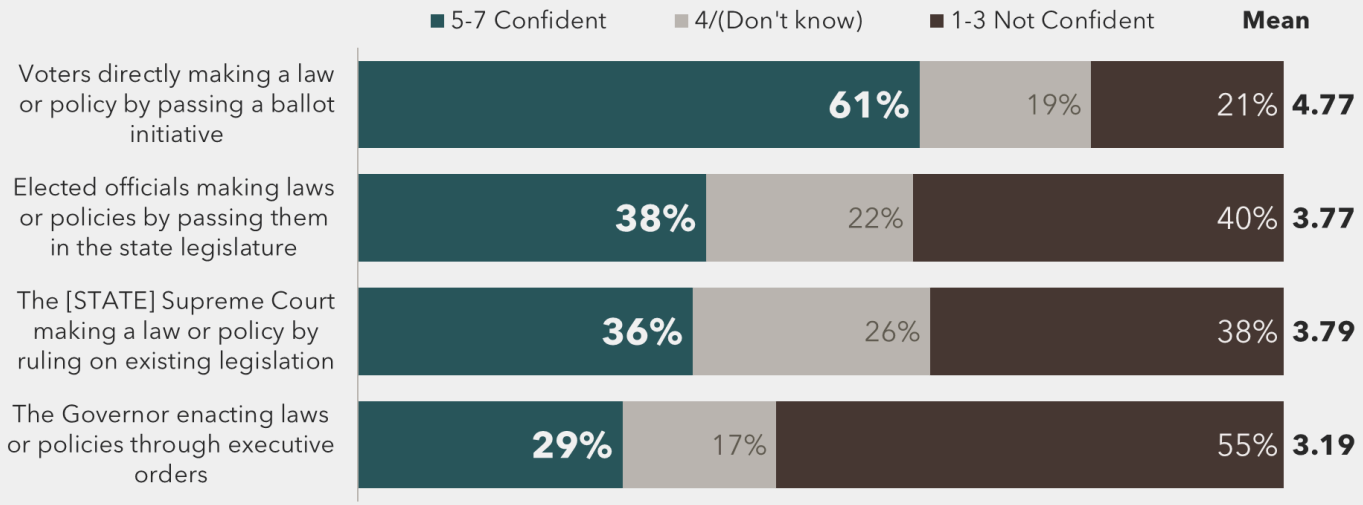
Across partisan and ideological lines, there is widespread agreement among voters that legislators should carry out the will of the people when voters approve a citizen-led ballot initiative. There is broad support for citizen-initiated policymaking, and a significant majority of voters oppose their legislature limiting the ballot initiative process. Messaging that defends direct democracy is effective at intensifying that opposition.

Ballot Initiatives Drive Voter Engagement

Voters across surveyed states perceive themselves as relatively engaged in the ballot initiative process, with over four-fifths (83%) saying they vote on all citizen-initiated policies that make it to the ballot, and nearly half (48%) indicating that ballot measures make them more likely to turn out to vote. Half (47%) of voters say the process to get initiatives on the ballot is too difficult, including majorities of Democratic voters (60%), half of independents (49%), and one in three Republican voters (38%). Only 6% say it's too easy.

Voter Confidence Highest in Initiative Outcomes

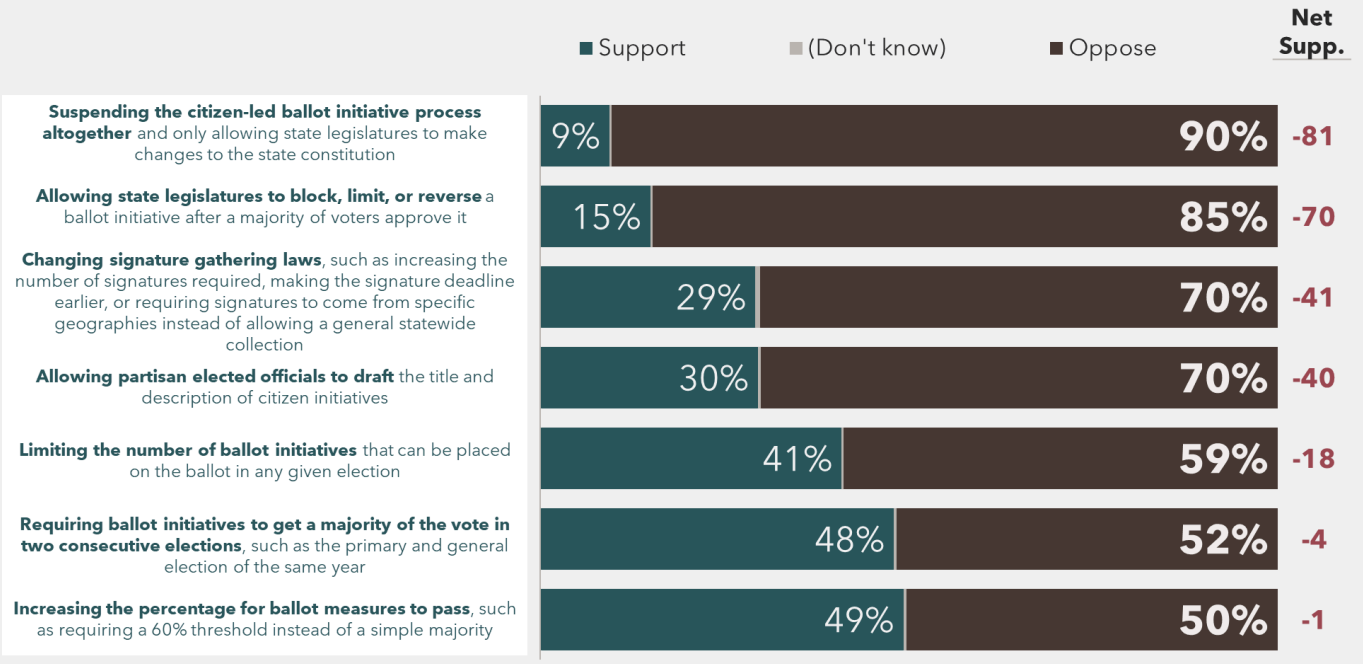
Voters are more confident in citizen-led policymaking than they are in other forms of government; a wide majority (61%) of voters are confident that ballot initiatives lead to good policies for the state, and pluralities of voters are <u>not</u> confident in those outcomes when policies come from the legislature, governor, or their state supreme court.



Protecting Citizen-Led Policymaking is Key

When forced to choose between whether legislators should be required to enact a measure approved by a majority of voters, or able to change or reject it, nearly all voters (83%) say legislatures should enact the measure.

An overwhelming majority of voters (71%) oppose the state legislature limiting the ballot initiative process outright. Voters are opposed to a variety of mechanisms that legislators across states have attempted to utilize to make citizen-led policymaking

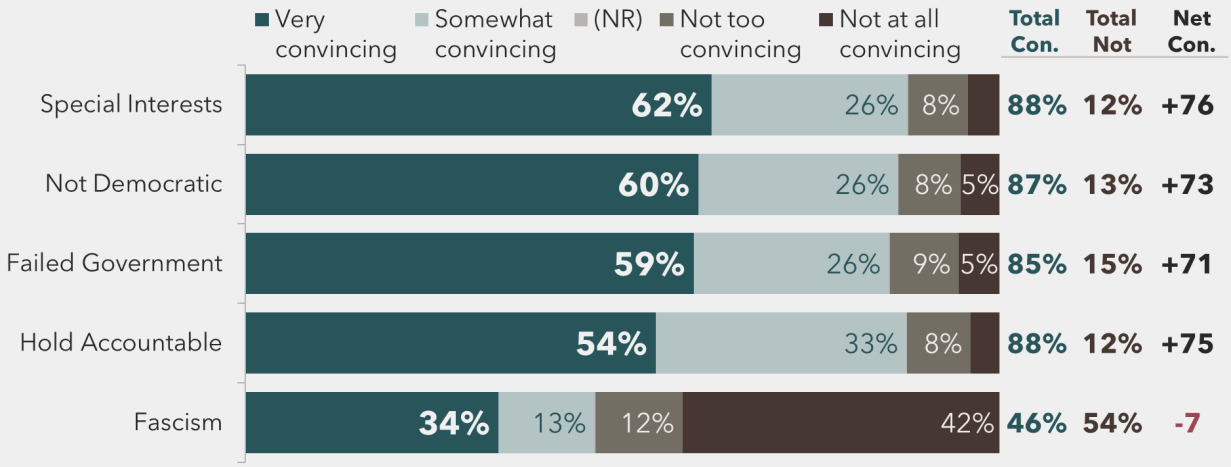


more inaccessible. Compared to multi-state research conducted in 2023[1], opposition to increasing passage thresholds and changing signature gathering laws has increased.

Supporting efforts to overturn citizen-led, voter-approved policy, or attempting to limit the citizen-led policymaking process, is also a risky bet for legislators facing election: 81% of voters say they would be less likely to support a state legislator who voted to make citizen-led policymaking more inaccessible in their state. Similarly, 83% would be less likely to support a state legislator who attempted to overturn voter-approved policies. Both of these results include wide margins among Republicans (74%, 78% respectively), independents (81%, 85%), and Democrats (93%, 92%).

Defensive Messaging Themes Stand Out

Voters respond positively to direct democracy defense themes, particularly ones that speak to the lack of faith voters have that elected officials will act in their best interest. Voters were asked a series of messages around protecting access to the ballot for citizen-led initiatives, and while a strong majority responded positively to most messages tested, partisan messaging about fascism alienates some otherwise attainable voters, with a majority finding it unconvincing. Of the 17% of voters who change their vote at any point, 56% find the fascism message not at all convincing. After hearing messaging, opposition to the state legislature limiting the ballot initiative process in their state rose to 81% (+10 points from the initial ask), including nearly universal opposition among Democrats (89%), independents (84%), and three-fourths opposition among Republicans (74%).



[1] Excludes FL. Tracking data from a 2023 online survey of n=230 voters per state conducted by EMC Research 11/27/23-12/3/25; included samples for AR, ID, MO, MS, and NE.

- ☑ **Special Interests (62% Very Convincing):** *Ballot initiatives allow regular citizens to make decisions on issues directly instead of relying on representatives who are beholden to special interests. Politicians should have to listen to the voters instead of limiting the process to appease donors who might oppose those policies.*
- ☑ **Not Democratic (60% Very Convincing):** *Limiting the ballot initiative process is an attack on our ability to participate in the democratic process. Even if we don't agree with every initiative on the ballot, people should have the freedom to vote for themselves on the laws that govern their lives.*
- ☑ **Failed Government (59% Very Convincing):** *Politicians have failed us at all levels of government, yet their power over our lives continues to grow. Ballot initiatives are one of the few ways voters can make their voices heard and we must fight any effort to take away that right.*
- ☑ **Hold Accountable (54% Very Convincing):** *The ballot initiative process is vital to holding politicians accountable. It is an important way for voters to overturn or change unpopular laws or to make sure that the issues they care about are addressed and cannot be ignored by elected officials.*
- 🚫 **Fascism (34% Very Convincing):** *Donald Trump and his administration present a unique and dangerous threat to our democracy. Since he has taken office again, attacks on our democratic processes have only increased with no end in sight. It is now more important than ever to do everything we can to protect our ability to vote on our state policies and laws.*

Research Methodology: Multi-State Ballot Initiative Research Findings

This memo outlines results from a poll conducted by Workbench Strategy from December 11-18, 2025 among 1900 registered voters in AR, FL, ID, MS, MO and NE[2]. Surveys were conducted in English, with some in FL being conducted in Spanish, via text and email invitations to an online survey. The overall margin of error is ±5.66 percentage points.

[2] Representative sample of n=300 voters per AR, ID, MS, MO, NE, and n=400 voters in FL

BISC Approach to Research

BISC's mission is to strengthen democracy by implementing a national progressive strategy for ballot measures rooted in building state-based power. We center the following principles when approaching our research program:

1. 1We conduct comprehensive research that includes quantitative and qualitative methodologies.
2. We collect data that gives us insight to a snapshot in time (like most traditional polling and focus groups) and we collect longitudinal data to give us insight over time through our Trendency panels.
3. We conduct research in the multi-modal ways that people access data, including text messaging, social media and online methodologies for gauging opinions.
4. We conduct research that allows for more complexity and nuance, utilizing scale - seeing participants as multi-dimensional, rather than binary beings.
5. We conduct research that helps us disrupt "monolith" narratives and strategies for BIPOC, immigrant and youth communities, to understand in more depth what is important to these traditionally underrepresented people — the people we center in our long-term, movement building work.

Contact Us

For more information, or if you have any questions, please contact Adam Snipes, Director of Strategic Partnerships at adam@ballot.org.